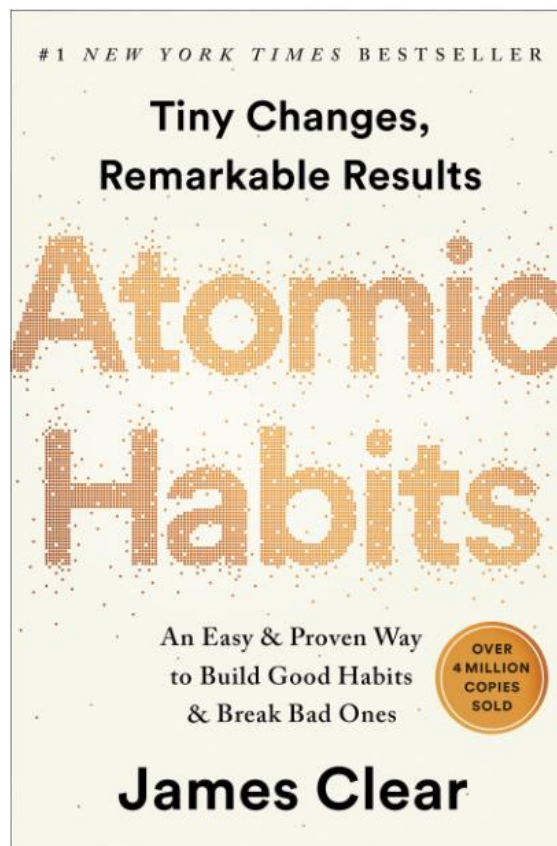


Is it just me, or is time seemingly moving by at an unprecedentedly faster pace? I find myself reciting the day of the week, out loud, each morning in an attempt to keep the days from slipping from Sunday to Saturday before I've savored as many moments.

This mid-Covid environment has caused me to ante up on an old and simple habit that is the one thing that I can trust to optimize productivity.

Allow me, this week, to introduce something a little different. It is a game-changing book that I read in 2020, reminding me of the one single activity that will help you make your days more relevant and optimize your productivity like no other. The book is Atomic Habits by James Clear. The particular activity is what Ivy Lee introduced to Charles Schwab in the early 1900's that changed his life, and the life of his legacy forever.



Here is what James Clear recounts in his book about the meeting worth \$400,000.

Schwab was the president of the Bethlehem Steel Corporation, the largest shipbuilder, and the second-largest steel producer in America at the time. The famous inventor Thomas Edison once referred to Schwab as constantly seeking an edge over the competition.

One day in 1918, in his quest to increase the efficiency of his team and discover better ways to get things done, Schwab arranged a meeting with a highly respected productivity consultant named Ivy Lee.

Lee was a successful businessman in his own right and is widely remembered as a pioneer in the field of public relations. As the story goes, Schwab brought Lee into his office and said, "Show me a way to get more things done."

"Give me 15 minutes with each of your executives," Lee replied.

"How much will it cost me," Schwab asked.

"Nothing," Lee said. "Unless it works. After three months, you can send me a check for whatever you feel it's worth to you."

The Ivy Lee Method

During his 15 minutes with each executive, Ivy Lee explained his simple daily routine for achieving peak productivity:

- 1. At the end of each workday, write down the six most important things you need to accomplish tomorrow. Do not write down more than six tasks.*
- 2. Prioritize those six items in order of their true importance.*
- 3. When you arrive tomorrow, concentrate only on the first task. Work until the first task is finished before moving on to the second task.*
- 4. Approach the rest of your list in the same fashion. At the end of the day, move any unfinished items to a new list of six tasks for the following day.*
- 5. Repeat this process every working day.*

The strategy sounded simple, but Schwab and his executive team at Bethlehem Steel gave it a try. After three months, Schwab was so delighted with the progress his company had made that he called Lee into his office and wrote him a check for \$25,000.

A \$25,000 check written in 1918 is the equivalent of a \$400,000 check in 2015.

The Ivy Lee Method of prioritizing your to-do list seems stupidly simple. How could something this simple be worth so much?



Portrait of Ivy Ledbetter Lee from the early 1900s. (Photographer: Unknown)

On Managing Priorities Well

Here's what makes it so effective:

***It's simple enough to actually work.** The primary critique of methods like this one is that they are too basic. They don't account for all of the complexities and nuances of life. What happens if an emergency pops up? What about using the latest technology to our fullest advantage? In my*

experience, complexity is often a weakness because it makes it harder to get back on track. Yes, emergencies and unexpected distractions will arise. Ignore them as much as possible, deal with them when you must, and get back to your prioritized to-do list as soon as possible. Use simple rules to guide complex behavior.

It forces you to make tough decisions. *I don't believe there is anything magical about Lee's number of six important tasks per day. It could just as easily be five tasks per day. However, I do think there is something magical about imposing limits upon yourself. I find that the single best thing to do when you have too many ideas (or when you're overwhelmed by everything you need to get done) is to prune your ideas and trim away everything that isn't absolutely necessary. Constraints can make you better. The majority of outcomes are driven by a small number of things that we do. Chances are that anything that falls outside of your top five or six critical tasks will have little impact. Basically, if you commit to nothing, you'll be distracted by everything.*

It removes the friction of starting. *The biggest hurdle to finishing most tasks is starting them. (Getting off the couch can be tough, but once you actually start running it is much easier to finish your workout.) Lee's method forces you to decide on your first task the night before you go to bed. This strategy has been incredibly useful for me: as a writer, I can waste three or four hours debating what I should write about on a given day. If I decide the night before, however, I can wake up and start writing immediately. It's simple, but it works. In the beginning, getting started is just as important as succeeding at all.*

It requires you to single-task. *Modern society loves multi-tasking. The myth of multi-tasking is that being busy is synonymous with being better. The exact opposite is true. Having fewer priorities leads to better work. Study world-class experts in nearly any field—athletes, artists, scientists, teachers, CEOs—and you'll discover one characteristic runs through all of them: focus.*

The reason is simple. You can't be great at one task if you're constantly dividing your time ten different ways. Mastery requires focus and consistency.

The bottom line? Do the most important thing first each day. It's the only productivity trick you need.

Today, before your day ends, write them down! This is a gift! Open it!